

A2-B1 · MAYA & EMMA ENGLISH

Stop Putting Things Off: 5 Easy Ways to Start

Do you say, I will do it tomorrow, again and again? Maya and Emma share five easy ways to start a hard task today, plus a speaking practice and a quick quiz.

Words in this episode

task	a piece of work that you must do	*My first task today is to answer an email.*
excuse	a reason that you give for not doing something	*My excuse is that I am too tired.*
put off	to wait and do something later	*I always put off my homework.*
guilty	feeling bad because you did not do something	*I feel guilty when I forget my friend's birthday.*
lazy	not wanting to work or to do anything	*I feel lazy on Sunday afternoon.*
distraction	something that takes your attention away from your work	*My phone is my biggest distraction.*
tiny	very small	*I will start with a tiny step.*
timer	a clock that counts the time and rings at the end	*I set a timer for five minutes.*
focus	to give all your attention to one thing	*I need quiet when I focus.*

progress	moving forward, getting closer to the end	*I am making progress with my English.*
reward	something nice that you get after you do something good	*A cup of coffee is my reward after work.*
motivation	the feeling that you want to do something	*I have no motivation on Monday morning.*

Say it out loud

1. I always put off my homework.
2. I will start with a tiny step.
3. My phone is my biggest distraction.
4. I am making progress with my English.
5. A cup of coffee is my reward after work.
6. And now, the quiz. I will give you a meaning. You say the word. Then Maya will tell you the answer. Let's go. Question one. Which word means, very small?
7. Question two. Which word means, to wait and do something later?
8. Question three. Which word means, something that takes your attention away from your work?
9. And question four. Which word means, something nice that you get after you do something good?

Transcript

Welcome

Emma: Hello everyone, and welcome back to our podcast! I'm Emma. This is the place where you can learn English with slow and clear conversations. Today we will talk about a problem that almost everyone has. Do you have a job or a task that you don't want to start? And do you say, I will do it tomorrow?

Maya: Hi Emma, and hi everyone! I'm Maya. Oh, I know this problem very well. I have a very tall pile of things I will do tomorrow. And tomorrow never comes.

Emma: Don't worry, Maya. Today we will share five easy ways to start a hard task. They are small, and they really work. We also have a speaking practice and a quick quiz at the end.

Maya: Please stay with us until the end, everyone. Okay, Emma. I'm ready. Well, I will be ready after a cup of tea.

Emma: Maya! That is the first excuse of the day.

Maya's sock drawer

Emma: Maya, before the five ways, tell us a story. What is the thing you put off?

Maya: Oh, it is a big one. It is my wardrobe. Three months ago, I said, this weekend I will clean my wardrobe. Then the weekend came, and I said, next weekend. And now it is November.

Emma: Three months! What is inside the wardrobe?

Maya: Everything. Winter clothes, summer clothes, old shoes, one broken umbrella, and a box of cables that I don't need. Every morning, I open the door and I close it fast. I say, not today.

Emma: And how do you feel when you do that?

Maya: Terrible! That is the strange thing. When I put off a job, I don't enjoy my free time. I sit on the sofa, but I think, I should clean the wardrobe. So I'm not working, and I'm not resting. I just feel guilty.

Emma: Yes, that is the worst place to be. You don't have the fun of resting, and you don't have the joy of finishing. Today we will help you get out of that place.

Why do we put things off?

Maya: Emma, why do we do this? Am I just lazy?

Emma: No, Maya. You are not lazy. You went to work every day. You made videos. You are only afraid of this one big job. Most people put things off for two reasons.

Maya: What are they?

Emma: One, the job feels too big. You look at it and you think, I don't know where to start. Two, the job feels boring or difficult, so your brain wants something easier and nicer.

Maya: And my phone is always ready with something nicer.

Emma: Exactly. A funny video is much more fun than a dirty wardrobe. Every time you choose the video, your brain says, great, that feels good. So next time it wants the video again.

Maya: So the problem is not that I'm lazy. The problem is that the job is big, and the distractions are easy.

Emma: That is the right way to think. And the good news is, we can change both things. We can make the job small, and we can make the distractions hard. Let's start with number one.

Way 1: Make it tiny

Emma: Way number one. Make the first step tiny. I mean, very tiny.

Maya: How tiny?

Emma: So tiny that you can't say no. Don't say, I will clean the wardrobe. Say, I will open the door and take out one shoe. That is all.

Maya: Only one shoe? That sounds silly.

Emma: It sounds silly, but it works. A big job makes your brain afraid. A tiny job doesn't. And when you take out one shoe, it is easy to take out another one.

Maya: Hmm, that is true. When I start, I usually continue. The hard part is only the beginning.

Emma: Yes. Another example. If you want to write an email, don't think about the whole email. Just write the first word. If you want to study English, just open the book and read one line.

Maya: I like it. Don't do the job. Do the first tiny step of the job.

Way 2: The five minute rule

Maya: Okay, I know the next one, because I tried it last week. Way number two is the five minute rule.

Emma: Tell us about it.

Maya: It is simple. You say to yourself, I will work for only five minutes. After five minutes, I can stop. And you really can stop. It is a promise.

Emma: Why does it help?

Maya: Because five minutes is not scary. Everybody can do five minutes. I put a timer on my phone, and I started with my wardrobe. I took everything out and made two piles.

Emma: And what happened after five minutes?

Maya: The timer rang. And I didn't stop! I was already in the middle of the job, and I wanted to see the end. I worked for forty minutes.

Emma: That is the magic. The beginning is the hardest part. After it, you have a little energy, and it is easier to keep going.

Maya: But some days I stopped after five minutes. And that was okay too. I did five minutes, and that is better than zero.

Emma: Exactly. Zero is the enemy. Five minutes is a friend.

Way 3: Remove the distractions

Emma: Way number three. Remove the distractions before you start. Don't fight them with your brain. Fight them with your hands.

Maya: With my hands? What do you mean?

Emma: Move your phone to another room. Close all the tabs on your computer. Turn off the notifications. If your brain can't see the distraction, it can't choose it.

Maya: I can see the problem already. My phone is always next to my hand. I pick it up without thinking. Even when I'm talking to you, I want to check it.

Emma: Then put it in a drawer. Or give it to a friend for one hour. It sounds strong, but it is a very good test. After a few days, you will see how often you want to pick it up.

Maya: Maybe I will put it in my wardrobe. Then I must open the wardrobe to find it.

Emma: Ha! That is clever, Maya. Now you must work with the wardrobe, and you can't use the phone. You also need a quiet place and a clear table, because a clear table helps your focus.

Maya: Okay. Distractions go away, and then I focus on one thing only.

Way 4: Start with the easy part

Maya: Way number four is my favourite. Start with the easy part.

Emma: Why is it your favourite?

Maya: Because I always think I must start at the beginning, and the beginning is the worst part. But it is not a rule! If I clean the wardrobe, I can start with the easy shelf, the one with only socks. I finish it in ten minutes, and I feel good.

Emma: Yes. When you finish one small part, your brain feels progress. And progress gives you energy for the next part.

Maya: It is like a game. You win the first small level, and you want to play the second one.

Emma: And you can use the same idea in other places. If you have a long report, don't start with the hardest page. Start with the page you know well. If you have a long list of questions in an exam, answer the easy ones first.

Maya: And leave the hard ones for later, when you are warm and ready. Good idea.

Emma: But there is one small warning. Don't use this to hide from the hard part forever. When the easy part is done, you must come back to the hard one. Okay?

Maya: Okay, Emma. No more hiding.

Way 5: Give yourself a reward

Emma: And way number five. Give yourself a small reward. After the work, not before it.

Maya: Oh, now we are talking. I love rewards. What can I choose?

Emma: Something small and nice. A cup of your favourite tea. A walk in the park. Ten minutes of your favourite show. A piece of chocolate.

Maya: Can I have a very big chocolate cake?

Emma: Only if you clean a very big wardrobe. The reward must be the same size as the job. For a small job, a small reward. For a big job, a bigger reward.

Maya: That makes sense. And I think a reward is more than a gift. It tells my brain, work is not only hard. Work can also lead to something nice.

Emma: Yes. And there is a bonus. When you finish, say to yourself, well done. Don't say, it was only a small job. Be kind to yourself. People who are kind to themselves usually start again more easily.

Maya: I like that. Well done, Maya.

Three common mistakes

Emma: Now, let's talk about three common mistakes. Mistake number one. Waiting for motivation.

Maya: Oh, I did this for three months! I thought, one day I will feel like cleaning, and then I will do it. But that day never came.

Emma: Right. Motivation is not a start button. Many times, you start first, and the motivation comes after. So don't wait for the feeling. Start with a tiny step, and the feeling will follow.

Maya: Mistake number two. Setting a very big plan. I said, I will clean the whole house this weekend. And on Sunday evening I did nothing.

Emma: Yes. A plan that is too big is just another way to put things off. Make the plan small. Today, I will do the shoes. Tomorrow, I will do the coats.

Maya: And mistake number three. Saying bad things about yourself. I told myself, you are lazy, you never finish anything.

Emma: That is very important, Maya. Those words don't help. They only make you feel worse, and then you want to hide in your phone. Try to say, this job is hard, and I will take one small step.

Your plan for today

Emma: Okay, Maya. Let's make a small plan, and I want our listeners to make one too. What is the one thing you want to do today?

Maya: Easy. The wardrobe, again.

Emma: Good. What is your tiny first step?

Maya: I will open the door, and take out the box of cables. Only that.

Emma: And then?

Maya: Then I will set a timer for five minutes. My phone will sleep in the kitchen. If I work for twenty minutes, I will drink a cup of tea. And when the wardrobe is finished, I will watch my favourite show.

Emma: That is a lovely plan. It is small, it is clear, and it has a reward at the end. Now, dear listeners, it's your turn. What is the one job that you put off? What is your tiny first step? Think about it for a moment.

Your turn: speaking practice

Maya: Okay, everyone. Now it's your turn to speak. Emma will say a sentence with one of today's words. After that, there is a short quiet time. Please say the sentence out loud. Are you ready? Here is sentence number one.

Emma: I always put off my homework.

Maya: Very good. Here is sentence number two.

Emma: I will start with a tiny step.

Maya: Nice. Here is sentence number three.

Emma: My phone is my biggest distraction.

Maya: Great job. Here is sentence number four.

Emma: I am making progress with my English.

Maya: And here is the last one. Sentence number five.

Emma: A cup of coffee is my reward after work.

Maya: Well done! You just used five words from this episode. Say them again tonight, before you sleep.

Quick quiz

Emma: And now, the quiz. I will give you a meaning. You say the word. Then Maya will tell you the answer. Let's go. Question one. Which word means, very small?

Maya: The answer is, tiny. I will start with a tiny step.

Emma: Question two. Which word means, to wait and do something later?

Maya: The answer is, put off. I always put off my homework.

Emma: Question three. Which word means, something that takes your attention away from your work?

Maya: The answer is, distraction. My phone is my biggest distraction.

Emma: And question four. Which word means, something nice that you get after you do something good?

Maya: The answer is, reward. And your reward today is a great new habit!

Emma: How many answers did you know? If you knew two or more, that is a great start. Listen to this episode again tomorrow, and try the quiz one more time.

Review and goodbye

Maya: Let's quickly review our five ways. Way one. Make the first step tiny. Way two. Use the five minute rule. Way three. Remove the distractions, and put your phone in another room.

Emma: Way four. Start with the easy part, and feel the progress. And way five. Give yourself a small reward, and say, well done. Don't wait for motivation. Start, and the motivation will come.

Maya: And remember, zero is the enemy, and five minutes is a friend. I learned that from my wardrobe. By the way, I found a very old sandwich in there. I will not talk about it.

Emma: Please don't, Maya! We have a small job for you today. Tell us in the comments. What is the one job that you put off? And what is your tiny first step? We would love to read your answers.

Maya: If this episode helped you, please like the video and subscribe to our channel. And share it with a friend who always says, I will do it tomorrow.

Emma: Thank you for listening, everyone. Take your tiny step today, and have a wonderful day. See you in the next episode!

Maya: Bye, everyone. Now I must go and find my wardrobe!